



muned but the extended Indian family all clustered under one roof to save money on rent, food and electricity bills.

R for **Kulhar Chai**, the kind that comes in earthenware cups and has a unique flavour. It's something that all Indian travellers are addicted to, apart from it being bio-degradable.

L for **Lassi**, the incredibly refreshing drink made by blending yoghurt with water, salt and spices or other flavours until it looks like shaving foam. In Punjab, it is drunk in such copious quantities that some shops even churn it in a washing machine!

M for **Mythology**, which governs millions of lives even today. It forms the bedrock of Indian culture and religion but it does often create a schism between belief and scientific reality: examples being the milk supposedly drunk by idols of Ganesh which created mass hysteria and, more recently, the Ramar Sethu episode which entails the belief in a God-made bridge between India and Sri Lanka. Of course, there are no greater myths than the ones floated by politicians and their sycophants, but the less said about that the better.

N for **Noise**, something we specialise in. We love making a noise, whether it is honking horns, shouting across the room at colleagues, playing loud music in houses or cars, or yelling at our servants. Indian cricket fans are the noisiest in the world, no matter where the venue. We live to be heard. In fact, for many of us, our lives are a scream.

O is for **Overloading**. Hit any highway and trucks, tractors or trolleys groan under a weight they were not designed to carry. It's the same with our buses and trains, with passengers happily perched on the roof. Of course, they may be happy because they are travelling for free, but overloading remains a popular national pastime: just look at the size of our state and Central cabinets.

P for **PCOs**, those ubiquitous booths that connect India like nothing else. Also for **Pakistan**, that pesky neighbour which truly unites India in times of heightened tension or war, as in an Indo-Pak cricket match.

Q for, well, **Queue**. Maybe it's the herd instinct in all of us, but whether it's for school admissions, ration cards, restau-

rants or film tickets, Indians are forced to form queues, of a sort. Safety in numbers could be one reason but even in the corridors of power, there will be endless queues of people waiting to see everyone from the minister to his PA and an even longer one to see the clerk who carries the files from one office to another. In fact, Indians require so many clearances for things that should be theirs by right, that a majority spend half their waking lives standing in the most unruly queues.

R for **Railways**, that behemoth transport system, among the largest such systems in the world, which ferries some 15 million passengers every day to each nook and corner of this vast country. No other system caters to such a large segment of India's unwashed, teeming masses, all with their bedding rolls and bottles of home-made pickle, where caste, creed and community are all united in an epic journey. No other place offers a microcosm of India under one roof as the heaving innards of a second class compartment does.

S for **Signage**, another uniquely Indian spectacle which often defies language, grammar and punctuation. On the highway, trucks will flaunt the universal message "Ok Tata, Horn Please", which makes some convoluted logic but only to the painters. Autorickshaws have taken it a step further with their own brand of philosophy, mostly to do with unrequited love, while shops have perfected the art of literal translation, as in the tailor shop which has a sign saying: "Suiting, Shirting and Panting". S is also for **Sari**, that innovative female garment which can hide—or expose—a multitude of sins, while it also stands for **Shrines**, those roadside appendages that appear as if by magic, with a small covered area, a gold-coloured garland and no ownership, but where every passerby will stop to pay obeisance. Finally, S is for **Spitting**, another habit that is as filthy as it is unhygienic but is done with such impunity by many, and with such alarming frequency that it's a wonder the country is not knee-deep in *paan*-stained gunk.

T for **Tiffin Boxes**, those aluminium containers, some a few storeys high, which carry lunch for millions of working Indians and schoolchildren. The tiffin carrier has lasted from the days of the Raj and still survives unscathed, despite the onslaught from more

